Violent Conflicts and Postcolonial Identity in Dul Johnson's *Deeper into the Night*

[1]Oluwatoyin Umar & [2]Isaac Barko Lar
[1]Plateau State University, Bokkos
[2]University of Jos, Jos

Abstract
Hegemony in northern Nigeria and the traditional boundaries that exist within the North Central, also known as the Middle Belt region, have led to identity conflicts and violent clashes in the region. This study examines the dynamics of the North Central identity and violent conflicts expounded in Dul Johnson's *Deeper into the Night*. With focus on the Tarok ethnic group of Plateau State, the novel brings the issues of religious and ethnic identity to the fore in understanding the characteristics of the violence. Johnson's novel stands as a laudable example in the literary corpus on the violent conflicts in this region, which is generally referred to as the North Central. The study makes significant use of the concepts of subalternity and hybridity as developed by Gayatri Chakravotry Spivak and Homi K. Bhabha, respectively, in Postcolonial Theory. The study shows that the assertion and preservation of identity is a major hindrance to the achievement of hybridisation of identity among the indigenes and the settlers in Plateau State. This work is a contribution to the study of *Deeper into the Night* as a text on culture and decolonization.
Key words: Identity, Conflict, Violence, Hybridity, Hegemony

Introduction
The Northern part of Nigeria consists of the eastern, western and a central geo-political sub-region, which is also called the Middle-Belt. Any evaluation of the North Central region requires an understanding of the polemics surrounding the identity of people from this region. Helon Habila considers the classification of the North Central states, tagged the 'Middle Belt', as "a classification most Christian parts of Northern Nigeria fall into culturally, if not geographically" (*Chibok Girls* 52). As a geographical entity, the Middle Belt includes Benue, Taraba, Adamawa, Plateau, Nasarawa, Kwara, Kogi states and the Federal Capital Territory. Unlike the Hausa-Fulani and Kanuri of the far north, the Middle Belt is populated by minority ethnic groups. The pre-independence agitation for its own region remains a major concern of the Middle Belt movement.

However, some people have attempted to characterise the Middle Belt based on a singular identity, an identity that separates every non-Hausa-Fulani Muslim of Northern Nigeria from the large number of minority ethnic groups in the region and an identity that is quite distinct from the rest of the Northern Nigeria region. Samaila Suleiman has expressed the view that since the Middle Belt identity is politically constructed against Hausa-Fulani Muslim hegemony, all non-Muslim, non-Hausa, non-Caliphate people of Northern Nigeria in states such as Kebbi, Gombe, Bauchi. Borno, Katsina, Kano and Kaduna may qualify as Middle Belters. Suleiman argues that "religion was the rallying point around which the Middle Belt consciousness was originally activated (18). There is, however, a contrary view by others such as Victor Egwuemi, who posits that the

Hausa-Fulani Muslims within the region cannot be excluded from the categorisation of Middle Belters (quoted in Emmanuel and Tari 1).

In the same way that the British administration has established a separation between the minority ethnic groups and the Hausa-Fulani people of Northern Nigeria, the definition of the Middle Belt, either on the basis of geography, ideology, history, religion or culture has resulted in a strong Middle Belt identity in the North Central states of Nigeria. The political agitation for the creation of the Middle Belt region is still ongoing. Nonetheless, just as Mvendaga Jibo has pointed out that "scholars may go by geography as contained in the current usage of North Central Zone" (8), in this study, the North Central region is considered as part of Northern Nigeria. Stuart Hall has posited that identity is whatever name is given to the different ways the narratives of the past position a people or the ways they choose to position themselves (394).

Hall's argument on positioning also appears to be describing, as well as supporting Matthew Kukah's summation on the identity of the people of the Middle Belt area of Nigeria, who are zoned under Northern Nigeria. Kukah in his 1983 essay titled "Christian-Muslim Relations: the Nigerian Situation", has said that the struggle of the people of the Middle Belt was tied to unwinding the foundation of injustice, which explains the struggle for a Middle Belt region and also explains the first political association to be formed in the region, known as the Non-Muslim League. According to him, they "seek a common cause by also defining their own identity" (2). Since they have been discriminated against on the basis of religion, they "decided to also seek a platform for defining their identity and asserting their rights and freedom" (2).

The questions of identity have been a subject matter for literary scholars from colonial times to contemporary writings. In the north of Nigeria, many scholars and writers have attempted to counter the views that the north is a monolithic entity, and have projected the religious dimensions to the Northern identity. Ahmed Maiwada (2010), Richard Ali (2012), E. E. Sule (2012) and Dul Johnson (2014) have expressly addressed this in their novels. People from this region are seen generally as people of the "Hausa North" by the Southern part of the country. The literary output about the Middle Belt identity, which is central to the conflicts in the region are few. Dul Johnson's novel is a significant contribution to the narrative. Indeed, Dul Johnson's *Deeper into the Night* aptly addresses the issue of identity and violent conflicts between the natives and settlers in Plateau State of Nigeria. As a matter of fact, Dul Johnson's artistry in the above novel portrays the conflicts that result from the struggle for power and dominance.

Theoretical Framework

Subalternity

Gayatri Spivak is known for her notion on "subalternity" from her essay, "Can the Subalterns Speak?". Subaltern is a term in postcolonial studies, which describes cultural hegemony and exclusionism in colonial politics. Spivak has expanded the scope of subalternity and attributed the term to the literature of marginality and suppressed groups of society. She focuses on the working class, women and the postcolonial subjects. Spivak is quite concerned with representation. Subalternity, as a concept of Hegemony, is about the marginalised and suppressed, which in this study is the minority or Middle

Belt group in Nigeria, who have developed some rage against the history that has stirred in them the need to assert their identity in every way possible.

Hybridity

Homi K. Bhabha challenges the view that cultures have fixed and unchangeable traits (9). *The Location of Culture* is Bhabha's key text in his conceptual evaluation of hybridity as a literary and cultural theory. Bhabha emphasises the interconnection and mutual creation of colonial subjects in the intervening ambivalent "third space of enunciation" (37). It is within this space that cultural differences may operate; an "in-between" space of cultural hybridity, which questions established categorisation of culture and identity. To Bhabha, culture is no longer a clearly bordered mosaic, but an overlapping of boundaries instead, which constantly calls forth the struggle between the dominant and the emerging (120). In essence, cultural difference among post-colonial people can be articulated in the hybridized space.

Hybridity has however been criticised by critics such as Benita Parry, Chandra Talpade Mohanty, Aijaz Ahmad and Vijay Mishra. Bhabha's argument has been countered on the grounds that hybridity masks cultural differences. Parry has argued that the third space of cultural encounter is differentially occupied, and that it was "contested space, being the site of coercion and resistance and not of civil negotiation between evenly placed contenders" (quoted in Bhandari 176). Bhabha himself agrees that hybridity "is not a third term that resolves the tension between two cultures…" (120). Seen in the context of the above clarification of definitions, *Deeper into the Night* has aptly exposed readers to the post-colonial conflicts of ethnic and religious identity between the indigenous people of Plateau State and the Hausa-Fulani settlers within Northern Nigeria.

Literature Review

Concept of Identity in African Literature

Identity is essentially the classification of people based on designated indicators. They are mainly physical markers such as territory, skin colour, language and ethnicity. Achebe, through various ways of representing Africa as a self-sufficient nation with a strong sense of cultural identity, has affirmed that colonialism results in the distortions of cultural identity. He devoted himself to correcting the lack of true cultural representation of Africa in literature. In his novel, *Things Fall Apart* the colonialist's interference is described thus: "He has put a knife on the things that held us together and we have fallen apart." (Achebe 145). Ngugi wa Thiong'o has also stressed the notion of identity and language in his quest for decolonisation. In his novel *The River Between*, Ngugi defends the ancestral customs of his people, the Gikuyu of Kenya, and asserts how a people's roots are planted within their traditions; going back to the past – the very beginning. (162). Another African writer who has addressed the issue of identity is Okot P'Bitek. In his *Song of Lawino and Song of Ocol* (1966) he tackles the issue of identity and conflict of culture. The main character, Lawino laments how westernisation has made her husband, Ocol, forget his African culture and begins to imitate the Western way of life. Ocol "pours scorn on black people/ He behaves like a hen /That eats its own eggs" (35).

The contention around the theme of identity in Northern Nigeria has continued to be a source of conflicts. Some writers from the north have addressed the misconception

that the north is a monolithic entity, and it remains a fact that there is a strong religious dimension to the northern identity. Even though people of Northern Nigeria are seen generally as the people of the "Hausa North" by the southern part of the country, the religious and ethnic differences that cause separation within the north continue to exist. In *Musdoki* (2010), a novel by Ahmed Maiwada, an author from the North, Musa Maidoki, the eponymous protagonist, along with some Hausa-Muslim men are fleeing the violence against Northerners in Lagos following the annulment of the June 12 1993 Presidential elections in Nigeria. While in flight, his co-travellers realise that the person who has travelled with them all the while, though a Northerner and a bona fide Hausa man, is actually not one of them. He is not a Muslim, thus he must be excluded from their common struggle. After their prayers at the mosque, in which he does not participate, they hurriedly eat their meal and desert him in Jebba. When he runs out to catch up with them the door is wrenched from his grip and the car drives off without him. As a matter of fact, Musa Maidoki (Otherwise called Musdoki) is a Christian. One of them retorts, "Don't mind the profligate! He entered the car when we didn't know. He can't enter now that we know. Drive on and let him rot there, as he should" (127).

E.E Sule's *Sterile Sky* (2012) also captures the problems of identity in Northern Nigeria. The non-Hausa people from other parts of the country live mostly in Sabon Gari of Kano city due to their religious and ethnic affiliations. Odula, a character in the novel faces antagonism for being from Plateau State but his boss shuts him up and says, "North is north, nothing like central nonsense, Plateau, Ha-wu-sa" (220). Similarly, in Dul Johnson's novel *Across the Gulf*, a Captain in the Nigeria Army, Janbut Rinbut, a Tarok man from the Benue Plateau develops a deep affection for Ifunaya, an Igbo girl during the Civil War. Ifunaya, the prisoner of war, wonders how the enemy, a "Awusa" man, could be so nice. Janbut tries, almost to no avail, to make Ifunaya understand that "not everybody from the North is Hausa" (45). Her parents repeatedly express disdain for Janbut and refer to him as "Awusa" Nigerian soldier. Richard Ali's preoccupation with the settler-indigene disputes and farmers-herdsmen clashes in his *City of Memories* (2012) reveals that the violence and outrage in the region stems from narrowed identities in the post-colonial Nigerian nation state. The author's view on the subject is most poignantly stated in Dibarama's words: "One of the most life-threatening problems that has bedevilled the modern African nation state is the question of identity, the question of who belongs and why, or simply, parameters for inclusion" (49).

Empirical Review

Deeper into the Night has been critiqued by scholars since its publication in 2014. In an article entitled, "Contextualizing Power Dynamics in Dul Johnson's *Deeper into the Night* and Olusegun Adeniyi's *Power, Politics and Death*", Joseph Christopher and Joyce Agofure have examined the novel. Analysed from the New Historicist perspective, the argument is that the author has deliberately created characters that are symbolic in their depiction of the many layers of power, mainly as found within post-independent Nigeria. These researchers conclude that even though the dominant class in Nigeria negotiates power within its structures, the dominated also negotiates and uses power for good or bad (90).

The novel has also been reviewed by some major voices in the North Central region. Hyginus Ekwuazi's review, as presented by Su'eddie Vershima Agema, has put forward a similar argument that the major theme of the work is power. Agema adds that the novel is easily the type that fits into the interjection of literature and history and argues that literature can be used to interpret history.

E.E. Sule, in an online review titled, "Violence and Identity: a Review of Dul Johnson's *Deeper into the Night",* says that the novel's impressive message is that violence comes in many forms – linked and interpenetrative – that is, in tackling one form of violence another form is likely to be created.

Discussion

Assertion of Ethnic Identity and Violent Conflicts

In her 1988 seminal essay titled, "Can the Subaltern Speak?" Spivak critiques the fate of the subaltern subject and how it can be marred by the politics of representation. Subjugated by hegemony, subordinated by the dominant culture and excluded from having any meaningful position from which to be listened to, the minority ethnic groups of the North Central region of Nigeria continue to assert their ethnic identity in North Central Nigeria.

In *Deeper into the Night*, the conflict intensifies as both the Tarok people and settlers in the fictional Plateau towns of Gwangtim and Taktim struggle to assert their ethnic identities. Old Gwangtim is the leader of the people. To be recognized by the government, his people want him to be named chief. Old Gwangtim's refusal shows his bitterness towards the people of Gwangtim for the desired change. He asks, "How can Gwangtim be the Chief of Gwangtim? Or have we become like our neighbours?" (2). He is referred to as "that old hardened mother tree" by the Emir of Karara Emirate, who is described as a self-proclaimed emir, Alhaji Danmatsi. This metaphor is used because of Gwangtim's cautiousness against the settlers and any foreign ways (5). Gwangtim's assertion reveals that while his community is gradually becoming hybridized in favour of the Hausa-Fulani hegemony, people like him have resisted all forms of incursion. Old Gwangtim's initiation of Mamzhi into a powerful ancestral group right from birth is to imprint his ethnic and religious identity on him. Sadly however, Mamzhi ends up with too much power. His supernatural power, which spurs him to heroic deeds for the emancipation of his people, soon turns him against the very people he first set out to defend.

The narrative clearly portrays the social and religious life of the people of Gwangtim. The story reveals the Tarok people's dedication to customs, habits, rituals and social life. Some of the important practices, which are directly linked to the identity of the people, include: settling disputes, how to appease the ancestors, marriage and drinking of Mullak; the traditional protective charm to ward off evil spirits, among others. The people of Gwangtim are prosperous and they live a happy and contented life. The ways of the people, as depicted in the novel is free from daily tensions and conflicts that plague the lives of people of modern civilised societies.

However, soon after the death of Old Gwangtim and Nimfa's friendship with Alhaji Danmatsi, major changes begin. These changes are announced by the physical transformations in Gwangtim. Rounded thatched huts give way to brick structures. There

are signboards announcing projects yet to commence. Shacks are erected by the road sides and houses spring up on some plots of land that had none (123). Also, drinking of Nche, a locally brewed bear that is meant for elders, is abused by the youth. "No reasonable boy would see elders drinking and will look at them twice, not to talk of asking for some to drink! Has our culture been swept away that much?" (191).

A preference for staying rooted in the way of life of the people is also illustrated with the character, Kumtur. Kumtur has been in the city. He returns home to Gwangtim with his family. When his daughter Julchit seeks permission to go and play but is blocked by her brother Jangbut because she cannot dance, Kumtur tells him to let her go. He explains, "That is why we are returning home, so that you all will grow up as proper Tarok children" (38).

Nimfa, Gwangtim's greedy and over-ambitous son who is also selfish, lays claim to the throne, and he enters into a crooked arrangement with the Emir of Karara. This further gives the Emir the much-coveted newer territories in order to "to extend his influence" (3). The people are outraged. The brewing conflict breaks out into violence that leaves the community broken. The author shows the extent to which violence devastates the Gwangtim community. It is during the conflict in Gwangtim that Mamzhi, who has been called The Strange One because of his supernatural traits and rare wisdom, rises to the occasion and distinguishes himself as the hero of his people.

The cosmopolitan city of Jos, which has experienced violent conflict on a larger scale, witnesses ethnic and religious violence even before the rural settlements in the state. In the Jos crisis, anyone who is not a Muslim is automatically conscripted into Christianity. Mamzhi is caught up in one of the crises in the course of his visit to the city of Jos in search of his lover, Julchit. The religious crisis breaks out between Christians and Muslims. Mazhi is quickly enlisted to fight in an emergency civilian militia. It is during this time that Mamzhi first experiences and exhibits his powers. During the crisis, it is either one is a Christian or a Muslim.

Tyem Zhimak is the chief of Taktim. He is a historian, the custodian of culture and Taktim ancestry. Tyem is so committed to living out his convictions to the point that Chirmam, while growing up has woken up to his father's daily chant on his musical instrument called abwa. He sings to the melody of the abwa thus:

> I am Tyem, the son of Zhimak and Mokem,
> Zhimak, son of Binfa, begotten of Fanzhi,
> Born in the days of the Whiteman, men
> Who fought and resisted the Whiteman.
> I am the grandson of Fanzhi born of Mamwor,
> Fanzhi, the son of Mamtip, born of Lengler,
> The son of Dombong, great warrior of many,
> Many years before the Whiteman, Dombong,
> Whose ancestors, descended from Gandulong,
> Greatest farmers and warriors, favoured of Inan,
> The great Inan, creator of all things,
> Of all people – great Inan, I am your servant,
> Great Inan, I worship you, for the blessings... (14-15).

Tyem chants these words daily to his son Chirmam, in order to preserve his ancestry as well as teaching lessons in culture, tradition and living. He also tells Chirmam stories in the early part of the night. Tyem talks to his son about the sovereignty and love of Inan, and ends with lessons to encourage him to trust completely in Inan because there is none like Him (15). Tyem has a modern compound but never likes to eat food or drink gruel prepared from flour ground by the Whiteman's machine. He prefers the grinding stone (14). Like Gwangtim, Tyem seeks to pass on his legacy to his son, Chirmam. To Tyem's great disappointment however, Chirmam abandons his father's ancestral heritage and turns to Christianity.

Tyem is also angry that his son Chirmam has not just left his culture to adopt a foreign one, but has also changed his name. In the light of Bhabha's theory, cultural hybridity takes place when a person is caught between two different cultures. This leads such a person to develop a double consciousness, which ultimately results in a merged (sometimes lost) identity. Chirmam changes his Tarok name to a Hausa one, Iliya, the Hausa translation of Elijah. This change of name is like a process of rejecting his cultural identity. Chirmam later questions his father's identity and belief (17). Language is central to the identity of a people. Omobowale, has noted that "the centrality of diffusion and the consequent prominence of Hausa have given the language and culture a hegemonic character which at times silences the other languages and cultures" (quoted in Joseph 24). Chirmam goes as far as challenging Nimyel, the idol worshipper who named him Chirmam. For such betrayal of his people's culture, Chirmam receives a blinding slap that gives him a red eye for weeks. Nimyel claims that it is the idol that has dealt with Chirmam and asks him to dare him again (20). Tyem, in defence of his culture, tells his son that if there's no Tarok equivalence of Elijah then "we are outside of his God" (17). Chirmam is an example of how Christianity and colonialism have influenced or redefined the identity of non-Muslims in the Middle Belt.

Matthew Kukah has surmised that the colonial administration had deliberately designed "an architecture of power that subordinated the non-Muslim communities that would later be known as the Emirate System" in order to consolidate their relations with the Fulani ruling class and fully exploit its economic benefits (1). The emirate system is considered to be the British aggrandizement of Hausa-Fulani ethnic identity. In *Deeper into the Night*, The Hausa-Fulani settlers seek to preserve their identity within the land in which they have come to settle, but in a manner that the host community quickly perceives as domination. Alhaji Nisa speaks figuratively of how the pond flows into the sea and tells Tyem irreverently, "I will become one of your subjects". However, his refusal to integrate into the host community is made clear by his many disdainful actions.

Tyem contends for his territory with Alhaji Maiguguwa Nisa. Alhaji Nisa is a settler in Gwangtim. Nisa claims that he has come to Taktim, a Tarok community in order to teach his fellow Muslims how to pray on the authority of Alhaji Dampara Danmatsi, the Emir of Karara. Alhaji Nisa refers to the Hausa-Fulani community in Taktim as "a few" of the Emir's people, who are the emir's subjects. Tyem asks, "In my own community? His subjects?" (32). Nisa insists that there is a need for an Imam to lead the prayers for the Muslims in Gwangtim. Tyem, on the other hand says that he is in charge and two leaders cannot exist in one community; and definitely, not a settler.

Nisa draws the battle line on his arrival at Taktim. Not only does he declare that he has come to stay as the representative of the Emir of Karara; indeed, according to Alhaji Danmatsi, the Emir is far bigger than Tyem's Ponzi Tarok (31). The two men engage in a battle of assertion of identity, which claims both lives eventually. Subsequently, Nisa controls the sales of farm produce and gets the authorities' approval to mine and organise the market for the newly discovered precious stones in Taktim. Finally, to Tyem's chagrin, Alhaji Nisa insists that he is the owner of the land given to him by Tyem when he first arrived at Taktim. He says "What do you mean by steal your land, Tyem Zimak? You came to this place before me, took land and used. Then, I came, and you had to give up part of it to me, that is all. Or are you Allah?" The long battle that ensues over these land issues leads to violent conflicts in Taktim. Nisa masterminds a violent attack on the village and both he and Zhimak are killed.

The colonial administrative perfidy reinforced Hausa-Fulani hegemony in the North Central region socio-economic and political disadvantage. Both Gwangtim and Tyem Zhimak stand as a strong agent against hegemonic domination and influence, which they see as a threat to their people's identity. The people also refuse to remain silent in the face of post-colonial hegemony. Hostility develops between them and the settlers in their midst. The Tarok communities of Gwantim and Taktim later join efforts in order to resist an attack from the powerful Hausa-Fulani emirate. Mamzhi is the dreaded warlord that leads the community to victory. He uses his experience in the Jos crisis to train the youth and retired members of the armed forces on how to strategise and achieve victory.

The Question of Hybridity and the Settler-Indigene Identity conflicts

Scholars and theorists of postcolonialism have linked the complexity of the subject of identity to colonialism. To Bhabha, culture in post-colonial societies is no longer a clearly bordered mosaic, but an overlapping of boundaries instead, which constantly calls forth the struggle between the dominant and the emerging (120).

Hybridization takes many forms: linguistic, cultural, political and racial, among others. (Ashcroft et al. *KeyConcepts* 108). This study explores the various examples in Dul Johnson's novel. As Old Gwangtim's replacement, Nimfa stops the practice of calling all the leaders of the neighbouring villages to his house for the ceremony of appeasing the ancestors twice in a year (73). Nimfa also throws away the pot that Gwangtim keeps the mullak, as well as the more than fifty-year old Nkpangang, his father's staff of office. He ends up however with a syncretism of both religions. For Nimfa, the borders become blurred. Danmatsi clearly tells Nimfa that the title he desires is associated with Islam: "Have you settled with your ancestors now? What I wear does not depict my title; it depicts my religion". It is worthy to note that in Northern Nigeria, ethnicity and religion go hand-in-hand. The emir courts Nimfa's friendship because he has long had his eyes on Gwangtim, and during this period, he finds Nimfa willing and eager, unlike his father. Furthemore, "He also noticed that Nimfa secretly admired his outfit, the turban in particular" (4).

On the other hand, the deep-rooted pre-colonial Islamic – Arabic influence has strongly contributed to defining and shaping the Northern Nigeria Muslim hybrid identity. In an assertion that describes the Middle Belt situation, Edward Said has rightly

noted that imperialism has consolidated the mixture of cultures, while paradoxically promoting exclusive identities (1). According to Albert Gérard, “the Muslim cultures of black Africa have shown uncommon resilience to the impact of Europe, presumably because they are proudly grounded in one of the great religions of the world” (20). Alhaji Nisa does not hesitate to make it clear from the onset that he has no intentions of integrating with the people of Taktim. As the tension between Tyem and Alhaji Nisa buids up to fever pitch, Tyem makes it clear to Nisa that they do not have anything in common. His aim of going to Nisa's house very early is to get Nisa to say the truth about his intentions on the piece of land which he aims to forcefully intends to claim from Nimfa, as quoted below:

> For your Allahhh, Tyem Zhimak said it again, imitating Nisa's pronunciation. Tell him that Tyem Zhimak said you are a greedy and coveteous man; that you have abandoned the land he gave you. And that the land on which the Almighty God in his infinite wisdom and mercy placed me is now the bone of contention between the two of us. Tell him to intervene if he can, but if he cannot, let him let me know through you, so that I can take my case to my own God; the God who owns all things, who is just and firm (57-58).

Tyem advises his people not to sell their farms to Nisa for any precious stone excavation and not to sell their houses to him for any amount. According to Tyem, "Where will your children bury you if you sell your lands off"? Tyem Zhimak in this novel seems to hold a position against the hybridisation of cultures. He wants his people to remain culturally pure.

Conclusion

Bhabha has argued that hybridity “is not a third term that resolves the tension between two cultures…” (120). The Middle Belt people seek an identity of their own amidst ethnic and religious agitations. Today, in the region, Islam is synonymous with Hausa, and Christianity with Non-Hausa culture. The resistance against domination has continued to result in violent conflicts and guerilla attacks on Plateau towns and villages. This study has explored Dul Johnson’s treatment of these prevailing issues in the region. Furthermore, one finds that the text is a true representation of the Plateau conflicts. The struggle against domination has taken the forms of assertion of identity, outrage and violent conflicts. In spite of some level of cultural hybridization in the post-colonial North Central society, conflicts of identity between indigenes and settlers have resulted in hatred and continuous conflicts.

It is quite significant to note that the younger generation is failing in their role to take on the task of reclaiming what is rightly theirs. Both Mamzhi and Chirmam, the sons of the leaders of Gwangtim and Taktim, respectively, depict this failure in the different ways identified in this study. The recurrent ethno-religious crises arise from hegemonic struggles and the struggle for ethnic and religious identity in Northern Nigeria. The territorial conflicts in this region are directly linked to the colonial nation-state legacy in the purportedly homogenous North.

Works Cited

Achebe, Chinua. *Things Fall Apart*. Heinneman, 1958.

Agema, Vashima. "*Deeper into the Night* and Deeper Still into the Dialectics of Powers". *R*eview on *Deeper into the Night, Wordpress.com*,10 Aug. 2021. https://sevhagereviews.wordpress.com/2014/11/07/deeper-into-the-night-d

Ali, Richard. *City of Memories*. Black Palms, 2012.

Ashcroft, Bill, Gareth Griffith and Helen Tiffin. *Key Concepts in Post-Colonial Studies*. Routledge, 1998.

Bhabha, Homi K. *The Location of Culture*. Routledge, 1994.

Bhandari, Bahadar Nagendra. "Homi K. Bhabha's Third Space Theory and Cultural Identity Today: A Critical Review". *Prithvi Academic Journal*, vol.5, May 2022, pp. 171-181.

Christopher, Joseph and Joyce Agofure. "Contextualizing Power Dynamics in Dul Johnsons *Deeper into the Night* and Olusegun Adeniyis *Power, Politics and Death", Journal of Languages, Linguistics and Literacy Studies, v*ol.9, 2019, p.p 83 - 90.

Ekwuazi, Hyginus. "Deeper into the Night... and Deeper still, into the Dialectics of Power". *Blueprint,* October 28 2014. https://www.blueprint.ng/deeper-into-the-night-and-deeper-still-into-the-dialectics-of-power/

Emmanuel, Jonah Clangwak and Vahyala Adamu Tari. "The Myth and Reality of Middle Belt Geo-Politics in Nigeria: A Discourse". *Journal of Culture, Society and Development: An International Peer- Reviewed Journal*, vol. 10, 2015, pp. 1-8. www.iiste.org/tag/society-and-development...

Gérard, Albert S. "Sub-Saharan African Literary History in a Nutshell". *African Literature: An Anthology of Criticism and Theory"*. Edited by Tejumola Olaniyan and Ato Quayson, Blackwell Publishing, 2007, pp. 16-21.

Habila, Helon. *The Chibok Girls: The Boko Haram Kidnappings and Islamist Militancy in Nigeria*. Parrésia Books, 2016.

Hall, Stuart "Cultural identity and Diaspora". In *Colonial Discourse and Post Colonial Theory: A Reader*. Edited by Patrick Williams and Laura Chrisman. Columbia UP, 1994, pp.392-403.

Homi, Bhabha. *The Location of Culture*. Routledge Classics, 1994.

Jibo, Mvendaga. The Middle Belt and the Federal Project in Nigeria, Clestinno Publishers, 2005.

Johnson, Dul. *Deeper into the Night*. Ahmadu Bello University Press, 2014.

---. *Across the Gulf*. Sevhage Kikya, 2017.

Kukah, Matthew Hassan. "Christian-Muslim Relations: The Nigerian Situation", 1983. www.duq/Documents/theology/_pdf/vatican%2011%20Conference/Kukah_Christian

Maiwada, Ahmed. *Musdoki*. Mazariya Books, 2010,

Ngugi, wa Thiong'o. *The River Between*. Heineman 1965.

P'Bitek, Okot. *Song of Lawino*. Modern African Library Press, 1966.

Said, Edward W. *Culture and Imperialism*, Chatto and Windus, 1993.

Sule, E. E. *Sterile Sky*. Pearson, 2012.
---. "Violence and Identity: A review on Dul Johnson's Deeper into the Night". *African Writer 16* Feb 2016. https://africanwriter.com/violence-and-identity-a-review-of-dul-johnson-dee...
Suleiman, Samaila. "Exhuming Passions: Religion and the Emergence of the Middle Belt Struggle in Nigeria ". *Annual Review of Islam in Africa*, no. 11, 2012 pp. 18-24. http://www.pcs.uct.ac.za/cci/publications/aria/download_issues/2012/samaila%20Suleiman.pdf